> necessary … It is my opinion that after the Russians enter into war the Japanese will very shortly fold up. My object is to save as many American lives as possible but I also have a humane feeling for the women and children in Japan.[48]

Truman's reply to Russell appears to have been written on 7 or 8 August, before the Soviet invasion of Manchuria.[49] It is difficult see how the sentiments in Truman's reply are compatible with knowledge that a second Japanese city was about to be attacked.

On 25 July 1945 the commander of the US Strategic Air Force in the Pacific, General Carl Spaatz, was issued with a directive to use the bomb as soon as weather permitted, after about 3 August. The directive stated that a bomb was to be dropped on Hiroshima, Kokura, Niigata, or Nagasaki.[50] Thereafter, the instructions made clear that 'Additional bombs will be delivered on the above targets as soon as made ready.' This was drafted by Major-General Leslie Groves, the director of the Manhattan Project, who was keen to see both uranium and plutonium bombs used in the attacks. The directive was sent to army chief of staff General George Marshall in Potsdam, where he and Secretary Simpson gave their approval.

Responsibility was thus delegated to the USAAF to use atomic weapons in the light of operational circumstances. There was no separate political decision to drop the second bomb. When, on a rare occasion, Truman was questioned in public about the second bomb, his evasive response was that 'It was a military procedure, under which the armed forces decided that it would be necessary to destroy both towns.'[51] The bombing of Nagasaki became the first example of the delegation of authority to use nuclear weapons. It also appears to have been entirely unnecessary. The Soviet Union entered the war before the second bomb was dropped. As Tsuyoshi Hasegawa explains, the destruction of Nagasaki had little impact on the arguments within the Japanese Supreme War Council on whether to surrender.[52]

Whether the President knew of the second bomb, he was clearly aware there were more to come. Delivery of the third bomb to Tinian was accelerated, with the aim for it to be dropped by about 20 August.